FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

OFFICIAL MONTHLY PUBLICATION OF THE KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

January 2026 Vol. 33 Number 1 kcfb.org

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Groundwater in Kings County: Where Things Stand at the Start of 2026

As the calendar turns to 2026, groundwater remains one of the most closely watched and often misunderstood issues facing agriculture in Kings County. Over the past year, growers have heard a steady stream of updates, meetings, policies, and headlines. Some of that activity reflects real progress. Some reflects ongoing uncertainty. And some reflects the reality that groundwater management is complex by design.

January is a moment to pause, take stock, and separate signal from noise.

This article is intended to provide a clear, high-level snapshot of the groundwater landscape as it exists today, what has changed, what has not, and how to think about the year ahead with perspective as conditions continue to evolve. It focuses on context and posture. A separate article in this issue explains how recently adopted allocation policies work in practice.

WHAT HAS CHANGED SINCE LAST YEAR

One of the most noticeable shifts over the past year has been the transition from planning to implementation. In parts of the Tulare Lake Subbasin, groundwater sustainability agencies (GSAs) have moved beyond conceptual discussions and into adopting formal policies that outline how groundwater use will be managed over time.

This does not mean that groundwater rules suddenly became more restrictive. It does mean that local agencies are beginning to put structure around long-term sustainability goals that have

Groundwater 2026 continued on page 14

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Groundwater Allocations: What the New Policies Mean for Growers

A high-level look at the Mid-Kings River allocation policy, with an update on where South Fork Kings stands.

by Julie Martella

Now that the Mid-Kings River GSA has adopted its Groundwater Allocation Policy, many growers are asking the same question: What does this actually mean on the ground?

This policy establishes the framework for managing groundwater pumping locally as the basin works toward sustainability by 2040. It does not change water rights. It does, however, establish how pumping is measured, limited, and reduced over time.

This article provides a high-level overview of the Mid-Kings River and South Fork Kings groundwater allocation policies. It is intended to help readers understand the policies' structure, terminology, and direction, not to replace the policies themselves.

Landowners are encouraged to review the full adopted or draft policies that apply to their parcels.

TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN SGMA UPDATE

What the Allocation Policy Does

The adopted policy establishes a local system for assigning groundwater allocations, tracking pumping, and reducing use over time to meet SGMA requirements.

It establishes the rules that will guide how groundwater is shared and accounted for as the basin moves toward balance.

Public comments identified areas needing clarification and guidance on implementation. The Mid-Kings allocation policy has now been approved and is progressing toward implementation.

What "Sustainable Yield" Means for Your Acres

Every qualified, registered parcel within the Mid-Kings River GSA receives a sustainable yield allocation.

For the 2026–2030 period, that allocation is 1.43 acre-feet per acre per year.

This number is based on the 2020 groundwater model for the Tulare Lake

Groundwater Allocations continued on pg 11

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

A Steady Hand Into 2026

Dusty Ference

The start of a new year usually comes with plenty of predictions, promises, and confident declarations about what the next twelve months will bring. In agriculture, we've learned to be cautious about all three. What matters most is not how loudly plans are announced, but how consistently the work gets done once the calendar turns.

As we head into 2026, the Kings County Farm Bureau finds itself in a position that is both familiar and instructive. The issues facing agriculture have not suddenly disappeared, but the past year has reinforced how quickly circumstances can change and how important it is to stay steady when they do.

Over the last year, a significant share of our attention has been focused on groundwater and governance. That was neither accidental nor optional. The lawsuit challenging the State Water Resources Control Board's actions under SGMA remains active, and it continues to shape how state authority and local decision-making intersect. Legal action is rarely simple or comfortable, but it has been necessary to protect local control and prevent long-term consequences from being imposed without proper review.

At the same time, the lawsuit is only one part of a much broader body of work. Farm Bureau's role has never been to chase every headline or treat each new proposal as a crisis. Our responsibility is to stay focused on outcomes, protect agriculture from unnecessary harm, and keep decision-making grounded in local conditions. Some of that work is visible. Much of it happens quietly. Both are essential.

As an organization, we are entering 2026 with a clear sense of direction. We will continue to invest our time and energy where it makes the greatest difference for our members. That means staying engaged in water policy without letting it crowd out every other issue. It means maintaining strong working relationships with local agencies, elected officials, and partner organizations. And it means continuing to show up in rooms where agriculture needs to be represented, even when the conversations are technical, uncomfortable, or slow-moving.

We are also being deliberate about how we communicate. Farm Life remains a central part of that effort. This publication is not intended to be flashy or alarmist. It is meant to be useful. If something affects agriculture in Kings County, it should be addressed here clearly, accurately, and without unnecessary spin. That approach may not always be the loudest, but it is one we believe serves our members best.

Looking ahead, 2026 is not a year for shortcuts. There are no simple fixes waiting just beyond the horizon. Progress will continue to come through steady engagement, careful decision-making, and a willingness to stay involved even when results are incremental. That may not be the most exciting answer, but it is an honest one.

Agriculture has never been about certainty. It is about managing risk, adapting to change, and making the best decisions possible with the information available at the time. Farm Bureau operates the same way. We may not control every outcome, but we do control how prepared we are, how clearly we communicate, and how consistently we advocate for the people we represent.

As we move through the year, our focus will remain on protecting local agriculture, strengthening relationships, and keeping our work grounded in reality. There will be challenges ahead. There will also be opportunities. We intend to approach both the same way we always have: steady, practical, and focused on the long view.

Thank you for your continued support of the Kings County Farm Bureau. We look forward to the year ahead and to doing the work, day in and day out, that helps keep agriculture strong in this county.

SGMA Litigation: Costs and On-the-Ground Impact

Since filing suit, the Kings County Farm Bureau's SGMA litigation has required a significant financial investment. Legal and related costs associated with the case have totaled more than $600,000 to date. Those expenses reflect the complexity of the issues involved and the prolonged nature of court review.

At the same time, the litigation has had tangible effects for water users in the Tulare Lake Subbasin. As a result of court actions and ongoing proceedings, the State Water Resources Control Board has been prevented from implementing certain probation-related requirements while the case is reviewed. That has avoided the immediate imposition of state-administered fees and reporting obligations that would otherwise apply to groundwater users.

Based on the fee structure proposed during probation, water users in the subbasin have avoided costs estimated at approximately $60 per acre per year, as well as registration fees of roughly $300 per well. While these figures are estimates and depend on individual circumstances, they illustrate the scale of the financial impacts associated with state intervention.

This context helps explain why the litigation remains relevant even as local agencies adopt policies and implementation moves forward. The case has not changed the need for long-term groundwater sustainability, but it has influenced how and when state enforcement tools can be applied while broader governance questions are resolved.

Meet Your 2026 Kings County Farm Bureau Officers

At its October meeting, the Kings County Farm Bureau elected its officers for the coming year. This leadership team brings a mix of professional expertise, operational experience, and long-standing involvement in local agriculture to guide the organization through 2026.

Garrett Gilcrease — President

Garrett Gilcrease serves as President of the Kings County Farm Bureau. A professional agronomist with more than two decades of experience, Gilcrease has worked extensively in crop protection, fertility management, and practical, field-level problem solving across a wide range of San Joaquin Valley cropping systems. In addition to his professional work, Gilcrease helps manage his family's farming operation, which dates back to the late 1800s. The operation has included a mix of permanent and row crops over time, grounding his leadership in generations of on-the-ground agricultural experience in Kings County.

Chad Souza — Vice President

Chad Souza serves as Vice President of the Kings County Farm Bureau and brings deep roots in both agriculture and the local community to the role. A Kings County native who grew up on a family farm, Souza holds degrees in food science and works with farmers and ranchers through agricultural lending at AgWest Farm Credit in Hanford. His professional role keeps him closely connected to the financial and operational realities facing agricultural operations, while his long-standing involvement in Farm Bureau reflects a commitment to supporting growers through changing economic and policy conditions.

Zach Bickner — Secretary/Treasurer

Zach Bickner serves as Secretary/Treasurer. He is the ranch manager for his family's farming operation in Kings County, a multi-crop operation that has included tree nuts, corn, cotton, wheat, and alfalfa. A fourth-generation grower with a background in business and accounting, Bickner brings both operational insight and financial perspective to the role. In the Secretary/Treasurer role, he contributes a practical blend of operational experience and financial insight to the board's work.

Shane Bickner — Past President

Shane Bickner continues to serve as Past President, providing continuity and institutional perspective to the officer team. His ongoing involvement ensures that experience gained during his presidency remains a resource for the board and staff as the organization moves forward.

Together, these officers represent a balance of technical expertise, operational experience, and organizational leadership. As they guide the Kings County Farm Bureau through 2026, members can expect steady leadership grounded in the realities of local agriculture and focused on the long-term interests of the farming community.

Kings County Board of Directors

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

AG NEWS IN BRIEF

USEPA Announces New WOTUS Rule

The U.S. Environmental Protection Agency and the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers released a proposed rule updating the definition of "waters of the U.S.," or WOTUS, aiming to narrow what qualifies as protected waters following the 2023 Supreme Court Sackett decision. Public comments are due Jan. 5.

CDFA Announces $500,000 For New World Screwworm Surveillance, Training and Integrated Pest Management

The California Department of Food and Agriculture awarded $507,421 for a three-year project to improve New World screwworm detection, integrated pest management guidelines and producer training. CDFA and partner agencies are also developing coordinated response protocols for rapid reporting and containment.

White House to Limit Scope of Some Tariffs

Last month, the White House announced an executive order modifying the scope of tariffs originally announced in April. As a follow-up to newly announced trade deals and ongoing negotiations, it expects reciprocal tariffs to be dropped on the following agricultural goods: coffee, tea, tropical fruits and juices, bananas, oranges, tomatoes, beef and some fertilizers. A full fact sheet can be found here. The announcement likely follows continued pressure via consumers on elevated costs on several popular grocery items impacted by tariffs. While some countries had previously worked to limit disruptions via new trade negotiations and deals, much of the world's economic supply chains have been impacted by the U.S.'s trade practices and its reactionary actions by countries such as China.

California peach growers file half-billion-dollar claim

California cling peach growers face an uncertain future after long-term contracts worth more than a half-billion dollars in total were voided by Del Monte Foods, which filed for bankruptcy in July. In August, the major canned foods company exercised its right under federal bankruptcy law to reject its contracts with members of the California Canning Peach Association, which represents about 70% of the state's cling peach growers. Del Monte's rejection of peach contracts has left several dozen growers without a future buyer for their fruit, exposing some to steep losses should they fail to recoup the upfront cost—typically several thousand dollars per acre—of developing their orchards. "We have lots of anxious peach growers not sure what the future holds for them," said Rich Hudgins, president and CEO of the peach association. This month, the association filed a claim seeking $555 million in damages.

Cal/OSHA Holds Workplace Violence Reg Advisory Committee

Cal/OSHA held an advisory committee meeting on Nov. 12 to review proposed workplace violence prevention regulations that expand the scope of employer obligations and definitions of hazards, including potentially adding criminal stalking to the standard. Farm Bureau and other employer advocates raised concerns about expanded coverage and infeasible engineering controls under the draft rule. The Standards Board is expected to refine the draft and issue further proposals in early 2026

Williamson Act Enrollment Reporting

Government Code Section 51237.5 states Williamson Act enrollment reporting is due on or before January 30th of each year. Once this year's data is collected, DOC will update its **California Williamson Act Enrollment Finder webapp**. Please let us know if you have any questions.

Reporting of Williamson Act enrollment has been simplified through the collection of data via Geographic Information System (GIS) files. This year's data should represent all Williamson Act contracted land in existence at the end of the 2025 calendar year.

Cabernet sauvignon has molecular memory of 400 years

The winegrape variety cabernet sauvignon was born about 400 years ago from a cross between cabernet franc and sauvignon blanc. Today, it is the most widely grown winegrape in the world. Unlike field crops that are replanted from seed each year, grapevines are propagated from cuttings. That means each vine is essentially a clone of its ancestor—and genetically nearly identical to the original cabernet sauvignon vine from the 17th century. Scientists long wondered whether epigenetic marks, which can influence traits such as fruit quality and stress tolerance, remained stable across hundreds of years of reproduction. Using advanced genome sequencing, a team of researchers at the University of California, Davis,recently determined the core epigenetic patterns, or "gene memory," of cabernet sauvignon vines have remained remarkably stable. "Even after centuries, cabernet sauvignon still holds the molecular memory of where it came from," said UC Davis professor Dario Cantù, who led the study.

Farm tech focuses on robotic weeding in vegetables

Weeding robots have emerged as a key focus of autonomous farm technology as growers seek solutions for costly and labor-intensive tasks. One model, which was displayed at the 2025 FIRA USA agricultural technology conference last month in Woodland, is the SharpShooter system from Hayward-based Verdant Robotics. The SharpShooter is a tractor attachment that uses artificial intelligence to identify weeds and deliver precise, controlled sprays without hurting the cash crop. "We're delivering milliliter streams of liquid onto the weed," said Chad Yagow, Verdant's director of agronomy and industry relations. "If you think about a hypodermic needle, if you press that plunger, that little stream of liquid that's coming out—that's what we're doing every time that we take a shot."

Early and late navel orange varieties spread out harvest

California's iconic navel orange—a signature citrus fruit for the fresh market—arrived in produce aisles right on time this year. Picking started Oct. 9 in Kern County, historically the first region to begin navel orange harvest. "Absence of a late summer heat wave and cooler October weather helped the crop reach maturity at the normal time," said Matt Watkins of Bee Sweet Citrus, a grower, packer and shipper in Fresno County. As fruit color and maturity develop, harvest will accelerate and move north to other counties. Navel oranges are harvested from fall through spring and may continue into the summer, depending on markets and fruit quality. Early and late varieties help spread out the harvest season, giving growers an opportunity to hit markets when prices are good.

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ECONOMIC IMPACT REPORT 2024

INTRODUCTION

Kings County agriculture remains a vital part of the local economy, fueling growth, creating jobs, and supporting community investment. This report emphasizes agriculture's contribution to the county's $7.7 billion GDP, its above-average wages, and its ripple effect across various industries. From supporting over 8,000 jobs to generating millions in property taxes, agriculture continues to anchor Kings County's economic stability and future growth.

KINGS COUNTY TOTAL GDP
7.7 BILLION[1]

KINGS COUNTY TOTAL AG GDP
1.1 BILLION[1]
OR 14.29% OF TOTAL GDP[1]

AVERAGE ANNUAL WAGES FOR AG
$65,644[1]

AVERAGE ANNUAL ALL INDUSTRIES
$58,005[1]

AGRICULTURE WAGES ARE
13.2%
Higher than the average in Kings County

AG PAYS APPROXIMATELY $44.3 MILLION IN PROPERTY TAXES EACH YEAR[2]

- **22.65%** to the County, Fire Department, & Libraries
- **13.94%** to Rural Development Agency
- **6.19%** to the Cities
- **6.09%** to Special Districts

MULTIPLIER FOR EMPLOYMENT

1.47[1]
Indirect and Induced Job Creation

For every job in agriculture, about one and a half more jobs are created in other parts of the economy.

JOBS TOTAL IN AG
8,139[1]

JOB TOTAL ALL INDUSTRIES 53,281[1]

AG makes up aproximately **15%**

1 Source: JobsEQ®, http://www.chmuraecon.com/jobseq
2 Kings County Assessor's Office
Annual Wages, 2024 Q4, Employment 2024 Q4, Economic Impact-Multiplier 2024 Q4; GDP 2023.

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SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

THIS EFFORT HAS SAVED GROWERS IN THE TULARE LAKE SUBBASIN $40-$60/ACRE AND $300/WELL SINCE KCFB WAS ISSUED A PRELIMINARY INJUNCTION.

CONTRIBUTE $15/ACRE TO THE SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Standardization Inspections Protect Consumers and Promote California's Commodities

In 1915 the California Legislature established minimum standards for fresh fruits, nuts and vegetables to protect both consumers and industry from substandard commodities entering the channels of trade. These standards, overseen by the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA), were set at the request of the fruit and vegetable industry. This program helps maintain confidence and stability in the marketplace, protecting growers, packers, buyers and consumers by keeping products described and marketed the way buyers expect.

The Standardization Program rules were written to make sure fresh agricultural commodities sold in the state meet minimum standards. Standardization rules written into California regulations and the food and Agricultural Code focus mostly on unprocessed commodities such as fruits, nuts, vegetables, eggs, and honey. The rules spell out minimum requirements for maturity, quality, standard container and pack, size classes, and container markings. They also include provisions that touch direct marketing and permit certain limited exemptions for producers selling directly to consumers.

What Inspectors Look For

Standardization does not only ensure consumers are purchasing commodities that are of an acceptable quality, but it also protects and promotes the fruit, nut and vegetable industries of California. The term "standards" in regard to fruit and vegetable inspection encompasses many things. Is the product of good quality? Is there bruising and/or damage from insects or disease? Is there other physical damage? Is it meeting the minimum size requirement? Is the product mature? Several commodities must be sampled, juiced, and tested with a refractometer to determine if they are meeting the minimum sugar requirements specific to those commodities. Is the commodity packed in the legal containers required for shipping? Many commodities have standard containers as determined by the respective industry and prescribed in law. Finally, is the product properly labeled with the identity of the product (common name), the party responsible (the packer's name), and the quantity (net weight or count).

How the Program Works Today

CDFA sets statewide standards, publishes regulations and guidance, and manages the statewide program. The Department's Market Enforcement /Inspection Services functions work to ensure the regulatory framework is maintained and periodically updated. Although CDFA oversees the rules, enforcement happens locally. Every California county has an Agricultural Commissioner who is charged with carrying out state laws and regulations within the county. County agricultural commissioners and their inspection staff perform the fieldwork inspecting fields and packinghouses, checking loads at wholesale distribution centers, and retail outlets, sampling products for minimum standards and labeling compliance.

Prior to 1992, the Standardization program was entirely funded by the State General Fund. An Advisory Committee was established to provide recommendations and advice to the Secretary of the CDFA on all matters pertaining to Standardization. Today, the program is funded entirely by industry, derived from a set container fee assessment. The revenue generated is distributed to the counties in the form of annual agreements.

In Kings County, 10-15 commodities are annually inspected by County Agricultural and Standards Inspectors, either at the time of packing in the field, or at the various packing facilities located throughout the county. Commodities such as cantaloupes, table grapes, citrus, cherries, peaches, plums and nectarines, just to name a few, are included in this list. The inspection work is now also year around, as citrus is being packed in Kings County from early fall through the spring.

The citrus program employs a set of rigorous standards and sampling procedures to assess the maturity of different citrus varieties, such as oranges, lemons, and grapefruits. One key aspect of the program is the reliance on the Brix measurement, which quantifies the sugar content in the fruit. The Brix indicates the number of dissolved solids in a liquid measure through its specific gravity. One degree Brix is 1 g of sucrose in 100 g of solution (1 Brix = 1% sugar). This measurement is a key indicator of the fruit's sweetness and maturity. The California Standard Brix for the Navel and Valencia orange varieties is 90%. Growers participating in the program submit samples from orchards, and these samples undergo meticulous testing to determine their Brix levels. This type of standardization inspection has kept marginal and substandard commodities out of the marketplace, protecting consumers and promoting California's fruit, nut and vegetable industries.

If you have any questions regarding the Standardization Program, or are interested in becoming a member of the Standardization Advisory Committee, please feel free to contact the Kings County Department of Agriculture at (559) 852-2830 or email us at agstaff@co.kings.ca.us.

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Observations from the 2025 Field Season: Blueberry Plant Decline

By Raymond Mireles, M.S., UCCE Fruit and Almond Area Advisor

Over the 2025 season, UCCE Fruit and Almond Area Advisor Raymond Mireles was called out to investigate sudden plant decline in a blueberry field located in the southern San Joaquin Valley. With assistance from UC Davis plant pathologist Dr. Themis Michaelides and his laboratory, disease-related plant death was confirmed. Diagnostic testing identified the presence of stress-associated crown and wood pathogens contributing to plant decline, specifically charcoal rot caused by Macrophomina phaseolina and Botryosphaeria canker. Charcoal rot is commonly associated with hot weather and dry or stressed conditions and has become more noticeable in perennial crops during prolonged heat events. Once established, the fungus can survive in the soil for long period of time and cannot be cured with fungicides. Botryosphaeria canker is also a stress-related disease and typically infects plants through wounds such as pruning cuts, cracked wood or other injuries, especially when plants are weakened by heat or water stress. When both diseases are present, plant decline can occur more rapidly, and symptoms may be more severe, including weak growth, dieback, and eventual plant death. From a management standpoint, there are no effective chemical treatments that will reverse these diseases once a plant is infected, so management must focus on prevention and reducing plant stress. Maintaining consistent irrigation during hot periods is critical, as even short periods of water stress can increase the risk of charcoal rot. Avoiding excessive salinity, preventing nutrient imbalances, and limiting unnecessary pruning or mechanical injury can also help reduce the risk of Botryosphaeria infection. Severely declining plants may need to be removed to reduce disease pressure in the field, and care should be taken to avoid moving contaminated soil or plant material on equipment. Over the long term, improving soil conditions and overall plant health may help blueberries better tolerate stressful conditions, yet these practices will not eliminate disease once it is present. These findings highlight the importance of laboratory testing when blueberry decline is observed, as aboveground symptoms alone often appear similar regardless of the underlying cause. As blueberries continue to be grown in hotter parts of the Central Valley, managing plant stress, particularly during summer heat, will be one of the most important tools growers have to reduce losses from these diseases. Growers, PCAs, and industry professionals are encouraged to contact their local Cooperative Extension farm advisor if similar symptoms are observed in blueberry plantings.

Figure 1. Cross-section of a declining blueberry stem showing internal discoloration consistent with crown and wood-infecting pathogens.

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

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WELLUP Program

EKRCD's WELLUP program provides farmers in its region and surrounding areas with the technical support to evaluate their farm's water supply health and plan for drought impacts and water shortages.

Program Benefits

Pump Efficiency Testing

- FREE pump tests for eligible producers.
- Up to 6 tests per producer (Non-SDFR).
- Up to 10 tests per producer (SDFR*).
- Available regardless of acreage or farm size.

Program Eligibility

To qualify for WELLUP submit an intake form.

Who can apply?

Farmers and producers in Fresno, Kings, and Tulare Counties.

Special incentives are available for Socially Disadvantaged Farmers & Ranchers (SDFR).

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Groundwater Allocations continued from page 1

Subbasin and reflects Mid-Kings' share of total pumping across the subbasin. The allocation is applied on a per-acre basis to parcels that are registered with the GSA and in good standing.

Parcels that are not registered do not receive an allocation. If unregistered parcels are shown to be irrigated, they may be subject to enforcement.

What It Means to Be a Qualified Parcel

In the policy, the word "qualified" has a specific meaning.

A parcel is considered qualified if it meets two basic requirements. First, the parcel must be registered with the Mid-Kings River GSA. Registration places the parcel in the GSA's water accounting system and identifies the wells associated with that land.

Second, the parcel must be in good standing with the GSA. That means the landowner is current on required fees, has complied with applicable GSA policies, and has no unresolved violations or penalties.

If a parcel meets both conditions, it is considered a qualified registered parcel and is eligible for a sustainable yield allocation. If a parcel is not registered or is not in good standing, it does not receive an allocation.

Transitional Water: A Temporary Bridge to 2040

In addition to sustainable yield, the policy includes transitional groundwater allocations for parcels that were irrigated at any point between 2015 and 2024, based on Land IQ crop data.

Transitional water is meant to provide breathing room as the basin moves toward balance. It is not permanent.

For 2026–2030, the transitional allocation is 1.0 acre-foot per acre, bringing the total annual allocation to 2.43 acre-feet per acre.

Transitional water must be used in the year it is allocated. It cannot be carried over, transferred, or used outside Mid-Kings boundaries. Only registered parcels in good standing receive transitional allocations.

How Small Parcels Are Treated

The policy also addresses parcels of two acres or less, which often come up in discussions about domestic wells and small parcels of land. Parcels of two acres or less receive a de minimis allocation of 2 acre-feet per year. This is intended to cover limited domestic or very small-scale use.

However, parcel size alone does not create an exemption.

If a parcel of two acres or less has a well that pumps more than 2 acre-feet per year, that parcel is required to register as a qualified parcel and follow the same groundwater allocation rules as other irrigated land.

Parcels of two acres or less that are not registered and are shown as irrigated using Land IQ data may be subject to a stop pumping notice. The de minimis allowance applies only up to the 2-acre-foot threshold.

In short, the question isn't just acreage. It's how much water is being pumped.

How Pumping Is Tracked

Groundwater use is tracked using Land IQ evapotranspiration data, adjusted for estimated surface water deliveries. Landowners with meters may submit meter data instead.

Each year, landowners receive an annual pumping report. Metered landowners may contest Land IQ estimates during the annual reconciliation.

Total pumping, including allocations and credits, is subject to a hard cap of 3.0 acre-feet per acre per year.

When Carryover and Transfers Apply

Unused sustainable yield can be carried forward for up to four additional years, with a five-year rolling retirement.

Only sustainable yield can be carried over. Transitional water does not carry over.

Carryover may still be curtailed if local groundwater levels, subsidence, or water quality issues arise. Extensions beyond the five-year window require Board approval.

Within Mid-Kings, sustainable yield and approved recharge credits can be transferred between a landowner's qualified parcels. This allows flexibility when some ground is fallowed, and other ground remains in production.

Transfers outside the GSA are allowed only under narrow conditions, including contiguity, a shared farm unit, metering requirements, and annual approval by both GSAs. Transitional water cannot be transferred under any circumstances.

What Happens If Pumping Exceeds Allocations

The GSA Board will set annual pumping fees for sustainable yield, transitional pumping, and recharge credits.

Pumping beyond all available allocations and credits is considered overdraft pumping and carries a $500 per acre-foot penalty. In addition, the following year's allocation is reduced by the amount of the overdraft.

Why Curtailments Are Still Possible

Even if a landowner is within their allocation, pumping may be further limited in areas experiencing groundwater declines, subsidence, or water-quality issues. Separate management plans will guide these actions.

A Note on South Fork Kings

Although Mid-Kings has now adopted its Groundwater Allocation Policy, work is still underway in the South Fork Kings GSA. In South Fork Kings, public comments have been reviewed through the advisory committee process and are informing draft revisions, FAQs, and outreach as the policy advances toward adoption.

South Fork Kings has been moving through its draft allocation policy carefully, with both the advisory committee and the Board taking time to review public input and implementation details before seeking approval.

At the December advisory committee meeting, members discussed comments received through workshops, written letters, and stakeholder forums. Those comments helped identify areas where additional clarification was needed, including how fallowed land is treated, how allocations and credits may be traded, and how the policy can be amended over time as conditions change. The Tachi Yokut Tribe's requested clarifying language was incorporated, and additional FAQs were developed to address common questions raised during outreach.

When the policy reached the Board in December, no action was taken. Instead, the Board directed staff to continue refining the draft before seeking approval. Discussion focused on fairness, cost assumptions, and implementation details, including how mitigation costs should be handled if a property owner drills a well and later sells the property. The Board also requested further work on well mitigation costs and the overall program structure.

Revised drafts are expected to return to committee review in early January, with the intent of bringing an updated policy back to the Board once those issues are addressed.

Where This Leaves Growers

This overview is not intended to be taken as gospel.

Groundwater allocation policies are technical by design, and the specifics matter. Landowners should review the policies that apply to their GSA, monitor updates as implementation progresses, and ask questions when anything is unclear.

The Groundwater Allocation Policy sets the framework going forward. What happens next depends on how well landowners understand their allocations, stay engaged, and use the policy's built-in tools.

This policy does not remove agency from farmers. It puts responsibility and opportunity into sharper focus. The more familiar you are with how your parcels are treated under the policy, the more options you have as implementation progresses. Clarity creates room to plan, adjust, and protect what you've built.

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

By Kings County Ag Crimes Unit

In December, the Kings County Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit observed a noticeable increase in agricultural thefts across Kings County, particularly incidents involving copper wire, heavy equipment, and agricultural chemicals. These crimes disrupt irrigation, delay field operations, and create real financial losses for local growers. The following update highlights recent cases and enforcement actions taken to address these incidents.

Copper Wire Thefts Impact Irrigation Operations

The Rural Crimes Unit has documented an increase in copper wire thefts from irrigation pumps, primarily on the west side of the county. Disabled pumps have disrupted irrigation schedules, preventing crops from receiving adequate water and resulting in crop damage, reduced yields, and costly repairs. Beyond replacement expenses, these thefts create operational delays that compound losses during critical irrigation periods.

Arrest Made Following Traffic Stop and Investigation

Detectives conducted a traffic stop on a vehicle suspected of recycling stolen copper wire. Two individuals were contacted and questioned regarding the origin of the material. The driver admitted to recycling approximately 1,100 pounds of copper wire but claimed the wire belonged to another individual and that he was recycling it in exchange for a share of the proceeds.

The driver later led deputies to the individual identified as the owner of the wire. During a subsequent search, deputies located a concealed firearm inside the individual's pant leg. The suspect was determined to be a convicted felon and was arrested on multiple weapons-related charges. Investigators believe this arrest will significantly reduce copper wire thefts in the affected areas.

Stolen Backhoe Highlights Sophisticated Theft Tactics

Rural Crimes Detectives also assisted patrol deputies with a theft report involving a backhoe stolen near 17th Avenue and Houston Avenue in Lemoore. The equipment, a John Deere 310LEP owned by Sunbelt Rentals, is valued at nearly $40,000.

At the scene, deputies discovered that the suspect or suspects had removed and abandoned the factory-installed GPS tracking unit. The removal of the device suggests a high level of sophistication and awareness of tracking technology commonly used on agricultural and construction equipment.

Chemical Theft and Vehicle Recovery Under Investigation

In a separate incident, approximately $45,000 worth of agricultural chemicals and a company vehicle were stolen from the area of 12th Avenue and Jackson Avenue in Hanford. The company vehicle was equipped with an aftermarket GPS unit, which allowed deputies to recover it near Interstate 5 and Panoche Road in Firebaugh.

Investigators believe the stolen chemicals were transported and dropped off at an unknown location in Fresno County. The investigation remains ongoing.

If you have questions or would like to report suspicious activity, contact the Kings County Sheriff's Office Rural Crimes Unit.

Groundwater 2026 continued from page 1

been discussed for years. The conversation has shifted from whether groundwater would be managed locally to how that management will unfold.

There has also been increased clarity around roles and responsibilities. GSAs, landowners, and partner agencies now have a better shared understanding of who is responsible for which pieces of the process, even as many details continue to be refined.

Finally, there has been a noticeable emphasis on communication and outreach. Agencies are spending more time explaining policies, gathering input, and adjusting approaches based on feedback from growers and landowners.

WHAT HAS NOT CHANGED (AND WHY THAT MATTERS)

Just as important as what has changed is what has not.

Groundwater allocation policies do not formally redefine water rights, but they do introduce new limits and accounting requirements that many growers understandably experience as a shift in how those rights can be exercised. Local groundwater management remains rooted in the framework established by SGMA, which emphasizes basin-level sustainability over time rather than immediate, across-the-board operational changes.

Local governance also remains central. GSAs, not state agencies, continue to be responsible for developing and implementing groundwater management approaches tailored to local conditions. Differences among GSAs are expected and, in many cases, appropriate, given variations in crops, infrastructure, hydrology, and community needs.

Equally important, there has been no move toward immediate, across-the-board operational mandates. Groundwater sustainability is a long-term objective with phased milestones, not a single event. That long horizon remains intact.

For many growers, this stability matters more than any individual policy detail. Knowing that the basic structure has not shifted allows for planning and measured decision-making rather than reaction.

HOW LOCAL AGENCIES ARE APPROACHING 2026

As GSAs look ahead to 2026, the prevailing posture is deliberate rather than rushed. Implementation is being approached as an iterative process, one that relies on data, modeling, and continued refinement rather than final, irreversible decisions.

Agencies are balancing multiple considerations at once, including sustainability targets, equity among landowners, operational feasibility, and the realities of farming in a variable climate. That balancing act helps explain why many policies include review periods, transition phases, or adaptive management provisions.

Another important feature of the year ahead is continued variation among GSAs. While all operate under the same statutory framework, the pace and form of implementation will not look identical everywhere. That variation can be challenging, but it also reflects local control in practice.

For growers, this means staying informed at the local level remains more useful than reacting to statewide headlines alone.

WHERE STATE OVERSIGHT FITS IN

While groundwater sustainability agencies are responsible for developing groundwater sustainability plans (GSPs) and adopting local policies, they are not the final authority under SGMA.

The California Department of Water Resources (DWR) is charged with reviewing GSPs to determine whether they meet SGMA's statutory requirements. That review process is separate from local adoption. Even when a GSA has completed significant work and adopted policies through its board process, DWR retains the authority to approve the GSP, require revisions, or identify deficiencies that must be addressed.

This distinction matters because local policy adoption does not automatically mean a plan is finalized in the eyes of the state. In some cases, DWR feedback may lead to adjustments or refinements to policies that have already been adopted locally. That oversight role is built into SGMA and has been part of the framework from the beginning.

In addition to DWR's review role, SGMA assigns the State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) a separate backstop authority that may be exercised if a groundwater sustainability plan is determined to be inadequate and deficiencies are not addressed through the review process. That authority is intended to function as a last resort within the SGMA framework.

In the Tulare Lake Subbasin, the application of that authority has been the subject of ongoing legal challenge. The Kings County Farm Bureau has filed suit challenging aspects of the SWRCB's probation actions and related requirements, and those proceedings continue to shape how probation authority is applied and understood locally. As a result, the role of the SWRCB in groundwater management is defined not only by statute, but also by the outcome of active court review.

This legal context helps explain why uncertainty can persist even as local agencies adopt policies and DWR conducts plan reviews. It also underscores the layered nature of SGMA implementation, where local action, state oversight, and judicial review intersect.

HOW TO READ ALLOCATION POLICIES WITHOUT LOSING CONTEXT

Newly adopted allocation policies often prompt immediate concern about what they mean in practical terms. That reaction is understandable, but context matters.

Allocation policies are frameworks. They are designed to guide groundwater management over a multi-year transition, not to dictate outcomes in a single season. Understanding their purpose and structure is more productive than reacting to isolated summaries or individual figures.

Details, definitions, and timelines matter. That is why this issue includes a separate article that explains how allocation policies function on the ground and what specific terms mean for growers. Reading these pieces together, not in isolation, provides a clearer picture.

The most important takeaway is that policies are tools. How they are applied and refined will continue to depend on implementation decisions and local conditions.

WHAT GROWERS SHOULD BE PAYING ATTENTION TO THIS YEAR

Rather than focusing on any single headline or meeting, growers are best served by paying attention to a few consistent themes in 2026.

Communication from local GSAs remains important, as updates and notices are often where the most relevant information appears. Understanding one's own operation, including acreage, wells, and historical use, also provides context for interpreting policy discussions. Asking questions early, before assumptions take hold, can help prevent confusion later.

This is not a year for guessing outcomes. It is a year for staying informed, engaged, and measured.

WHERE THIS LEAVES US

Groundwater management in Kings County is neither static nor chaotic as 2026 begins. It is evolving, locally driven, and increasingly structured. While uncertainty has not disappeared, the path forward is clearer than it was even a short time ago.

Understanding the current landscape does not require agreement with every policy choice. It does require context and patience. January is a time for orientation and planning, not panic.

The more clearly growers understand where things stand today, the more options they will have as implementation continues and decisions are refined in the months and years ahead.

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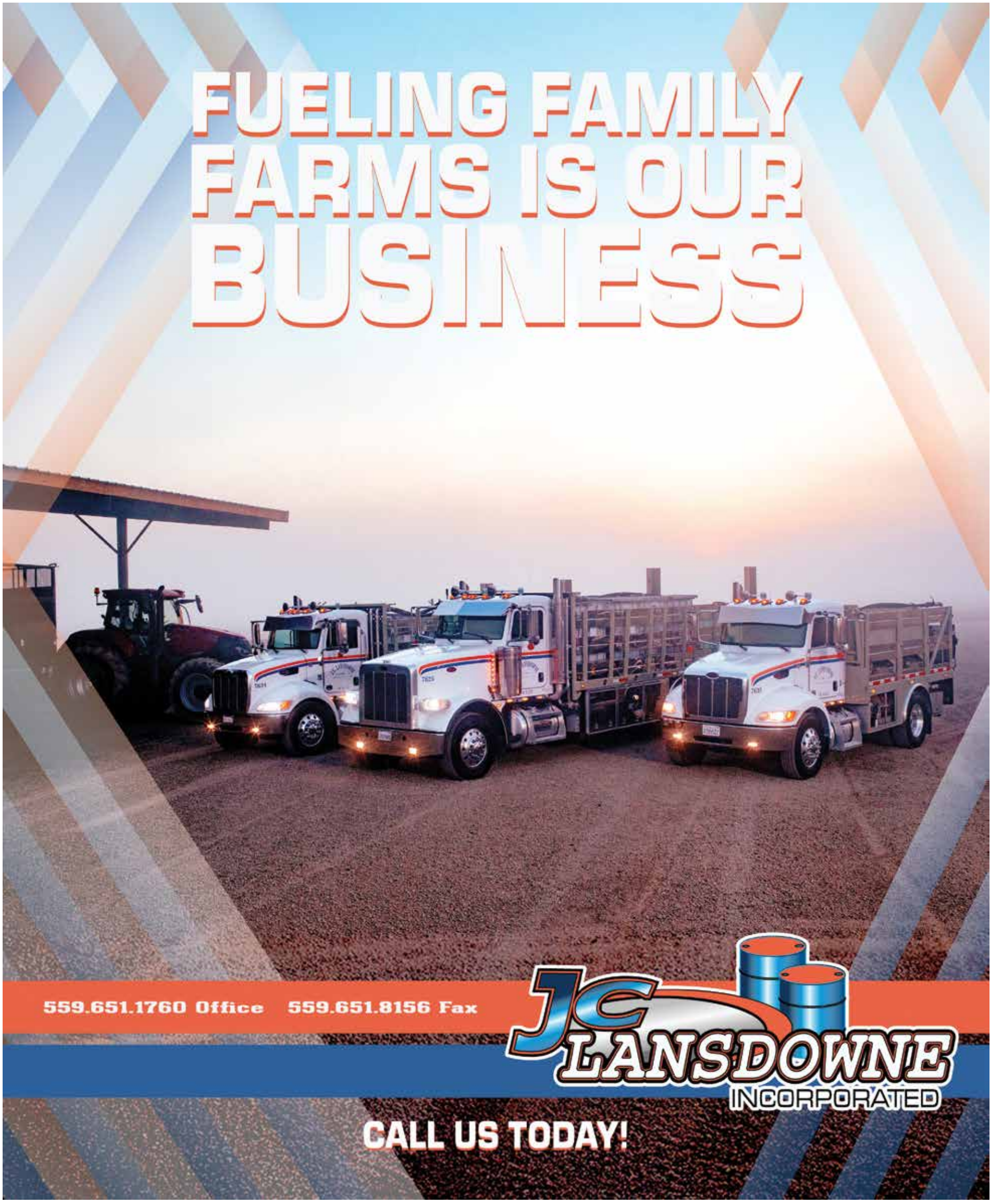
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